

Flow/being present in the moment

Being fully immersed or involved in an activity can really increase your happiness, because it allows you to let go of some of the general life baggage that we all carry around with us – the worries and fears, the guilt and shame that are all part of being an adult human. Doing this repeatedly, whatever the activity (think gardening, dance, yoga, running, reading etc) can have a similar effect to meditation, in that it gives us a bit of a break from our internal monologue, and this in turn can improve our happiness.

You're probably familiar with mindfulness, which we'll discuss in greater detail later on, and mindful behaviours can be a great antidote to the hedonic pressures of modern life. Flow, or allowing yourself to be fully present in the moment, is one of the core elements of mindfulness, and the wonderful thing about it is that you can apply it to whatever interests you. You might like to revisit a hobby that you loved during your childhood, or you might listen to music that you love, really loudly, until it fills your whole body and leaves no room for niggling feelings of not being enough. You could immerse yourself in stories or conversations, or learn a new language – anything that gives you a break from your own thoughts for a little while, on a regular basis.